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CENTERPIECE

Newburg farm continues after fire, silent auction set to begin

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Gabrielle Lajoie, left, and Heinz Thomet, farmers and owners of Next Step Produce, sit on the edge of their bar leftover embers in ashes of the boiler.

Ilana Williams/Southern Maryland News

The first thing to greet you at Next Step Produce in Newburg is a dog named Noisette, French for Hazelnut.

The second is Heinz Thomet, farmer and owner of Next Step Produce, harvesting grain.

The third is the smell of smoke.

On Oct. 1 at 10 p.m., a structure fire caused by leftover embers from a boiler inside the grain building engulfed Next Step Produce's barn, farmer and owner Gabrielle Lajoie said.

"It happened very fast," Lajoie said.

Then at 6:30 a.m., the southern part of the building, which was used to turn grain into flour, was on fire on the periphery.

The barn stored the farm's fall and spring harvest, seed and everything that is needed post harvest including grain cleaning, sorting, milling, drying and processing equipment, Lajoie said. The boiler heated their home and greenhouses, and dried the grain.

The farm has four large tractors, Lajoie said. One that was parked in the barn is the only one that has a loader in front. The farm is borrowing a skid loader and people helped remove insulation and metal sheeting on the roof and sides.

"Many of our wonderful people responded so quickly," Lajoie said.

A silent auction is planned to start on Nov. 1 and last four days to help the farm raise enough money to buy a new tractor, Zoa Conner, proprietress of Zen and Vitality with Zoa, said. Donations include a chef's tasting menus, speciality services and paintings and books.

A GoFundMe page has also received over \$60,000 to help the farm.

“We wanted to be able to help them get back on their feet as quickly and as effectively as possible,” Conner said. “Now is our chance to nurture them back.”

The silent auction can be found at givebutter.com/c/nextstepproduce.

Most of the corn and soybean that is grown in the region is for ethanol or animal feed, Lajoie said. Next Step Produce grows grain for human consumption.

“We try to grow food that nourishes people,” Thomet said.

The 20-year-old tractor was insured for \$20,000 and cost the farm \$40,000, Thomet said. Now with inflation, the replacement cost is \$100,000.

“We’re going to have massive losses,” he said.

The farm is also borrowing an outdoor boiler for the winter, Lajoie said.

An earth worm bin was transitioned into a drying bin on Oct. 20. Warm air from blue pipes were put under the bin to force the air up to dry the grain.

“We humans really depend on one another,” Lajoie said. “That’s why we’re so grateful for everyone that’s been showing up.”

Raphaelle Thomet, the oldest daughter of Thomet and Lajoie, was in the grain building cleaning popcorn that was harvested earlier that day an hour before the fire.

Leading up to the fire, she was in the grain building every day.

“We are harvesting our summer grains,” she said. “We had just started.”

Not only is grain that was stored in the barn growing in patches in the burnt barn, but Raphaëlle Thomet is transitioning into farm leadership. She is deciding how to continue grain diversity the farm offers.

“It’s what [distinguishes] us from all the other grain farmers and veggie farmers,” Raphaëlle Thomet said. “It’s a vision and a process.”



Inside the barn

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